> boots. He had two good looking large grey horses, one of which he rode and the other was led . . . He rode on a plain Persian saddle covered with dark cloth and had a short black cloth *shabrac*. He had Persian holsters and the stock of his pistols which appeared of Turkish workmanship were of ebony inlaid with silver. He spoke Persian fluently, but with a short, sharp foreign accent, never pronouncing the 'a' broad and full as the Persians do. He was a perfect master of Jagatai Turkish, but he did not speak the Constantinople or Persian dialects of that language.[10]

Rawlinson reached the Persian camp beyond Nishapur after dark, and asked for an immediate interview with the Shah. Admitted to Mohammad Shah's tent, he told him about the Russians he had encountered on the road, and repeated their explanation of what they were doing. 'Bringing presents to me!' said the Shah in astonishment. 'Why I have nothing to do with him; he is sent direct from the [Russian] Emperor to Dost Mohammad in Kabul, and I am merely asked to help him on his journey.'[11]

Rawlinson understood immediately the importance of what the Shah had just told him: it was the first proof of what British intelligence had long feared: that the Russians were trying to establish themselves in Afghanistan by forging an alliance with Dost Mohammad and the Barakzais, and to assist them and the Persians in extinguishing the last bastion of Shah Shuja's Sadozai dynasty in Herat. Rawlinson also realised he needed to get back to Teheran as quickly as possible with this information.

Shortly afterwards, the Russians themselves arrived in the Persian camp. To the ordinary Persians of the army, the Russian officer 'gave himself out to be a Musselman of the Soonee persuasion and declared his Musselman name to be Omar Beg. No one doubted in camp that he was actually a Musselman.' Unaware that Rawlinson had discovered the truth about their mission, the officer, introduced now as 'Captain Vitkevitch . . . addressed me at once in good French, and in allusion to our former meeting, merely observed with a smile that "it would not do to be too familiar with strangers in the desert"'.[12]

Later in life, Rawlinson would be famous for two things, firstly for deciphering cuneiform, and secondly, along with Arthur Conolly, for coining the phrase 'the Great Game'. But now it was his skill as a rider which proved most useful. He was, after all, the son of a racehorse breeder in Newmarket and had grown up in the saddle; he was also a man of enormous physical strength: 'six feet tall, with broad shoulders, strong limbs and excellent muscles and sinews'.[13]